



**THIS WAS  
TOMORROW**  
*IS THIS THE  
FUTURE WE WERE  
DREAMING OF?*

A PROJECT BY  
ENRICO POLICARDO



Supported using public funding by  
**ARTS COUNCIL  
ENGLAND**

# About the project

12 September - Open House Festival

Pollard Thomas Edwards - 10 Years of New Ground  
Diespeker Wharf, 38 Graham Street  
London N1 8JX

12 - 20 September - Open House Festival

Hastings Commons, Hastings

20 September - Open House Festival

Cressingham Gardens, Lambeth, London SW2

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a series of exhibitions drawn from a year of visits to community-led housing projects across England. Supported by Arts Council England, the work brings billboard-scale photographs together with recorded interviews with the people who live in these places. The first exhibitions open during Open House Festival in September 2026.

The visits include cohousing groups, community land trusts, self-build projects, co-operatives and off-grid settlements. At each site, the approach is the same: photograph the place, record residents' voices and ask, "Is this the future you were dreaming of?"

The photographs are reduced through a bitmap process to fields of black and white dots, then printed at billboard scale. They are pasted unframed onto walls, indoors and out, and left to weather over the run of each exhibition. No master file of the processed image is kept. Each print is generated again from the original photograph, so no two are identical.

Residents do not appear in the photographs. Their voices tell their stories instead. A QR code beside each print opens an audio page on the project website, where visitors can listen through their

own headphones. The recordings do not explain the images. The connection is left open, with space to imagine the people in the places they have made.

The exhibitions bring the communities into contact with one another. A Cornish quarry appears in London; a London estate appears in Yorkshire. Some of these groups have worked for years without knowing that comparable projects exist elsewhere. For many visitors, the places themselves will also be unfamiliar.

Alongside the exhibitions, [thiswastomorrow.co.uk](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk) holds a page for each community, with photographs, full recordings, an account of the visit, the history of the place and further reading. A quote generator draws at random from across the interviews.

Communities documented include Granby Four Streets and Two Up Two Down in Liverpool, OWCH / New Ground in Barnet, Cressingham Gardens in Lambeth, LILAC in Leeds, Calder Valley Community Land Trust in Hebden Bridge, Hastings Commons, Tinker's Bubble in Somerset, and Trevone Quarry, Kesoberi and Treneere in Cornwall.

## About the artist

Enrico Policardo (b. 1982, Gorizia, Italy) is a photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life and who gets to shape it - housing, the consumer economy, identity and borders, and the ways people make community. He is Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow



at the University of Nova Gorica. This Was Tomorrow began in 2022 with architectural historian Judith Martin, documenting endangered council estates in London, and took its present form following a residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto.

Supported by

Arts Council England. With the support of Simon Vickery (Open House Festival Programme Manager, Open City), writer and photographer Thaddeus Zupancic (London Estates: Modernist Council Housing 1946-1981), and architectural historian Judith Martin, co-author of the original This Was Tomorrow publication.

Press enquiries

For contacts and further info please write and email to [info@enricopolicardo.com](mailto:info@enricopolicardo.com) or visit [thiswastomorrow.co.uk](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk) / [enricopolicardo.com](http://enricopolicardo.com)

Press images available on request.

# IS THIS THE FUTURE WE WERE DREAMING OF ?

## Home

Home is more than a roof. It also means the people around us, how we live together and what kind of future we can imagine. The familiar path of marriage, mortgage and a life organised around one household is only one way to live, though it is often presented as the default.

The places in this project offer other arrangements. They have different histories and different problems, but each began with people deciding to make something together. That interests me more than the idea that independence means managing everything alone.

## How the work is made

I photograph the places without the people who live in them, then present their recorded voices separately. A voice might change how you see a photograph, but it does not tell you what the photograph means. You have to picture the people in the space for yourself.

The photographs are converted to black and white bitmap images and printed at billboard scale. I keep the original photographs but no master file of the processed images. Each print is generated again, so the pattern of dots varies from one printing to the next.

## Why

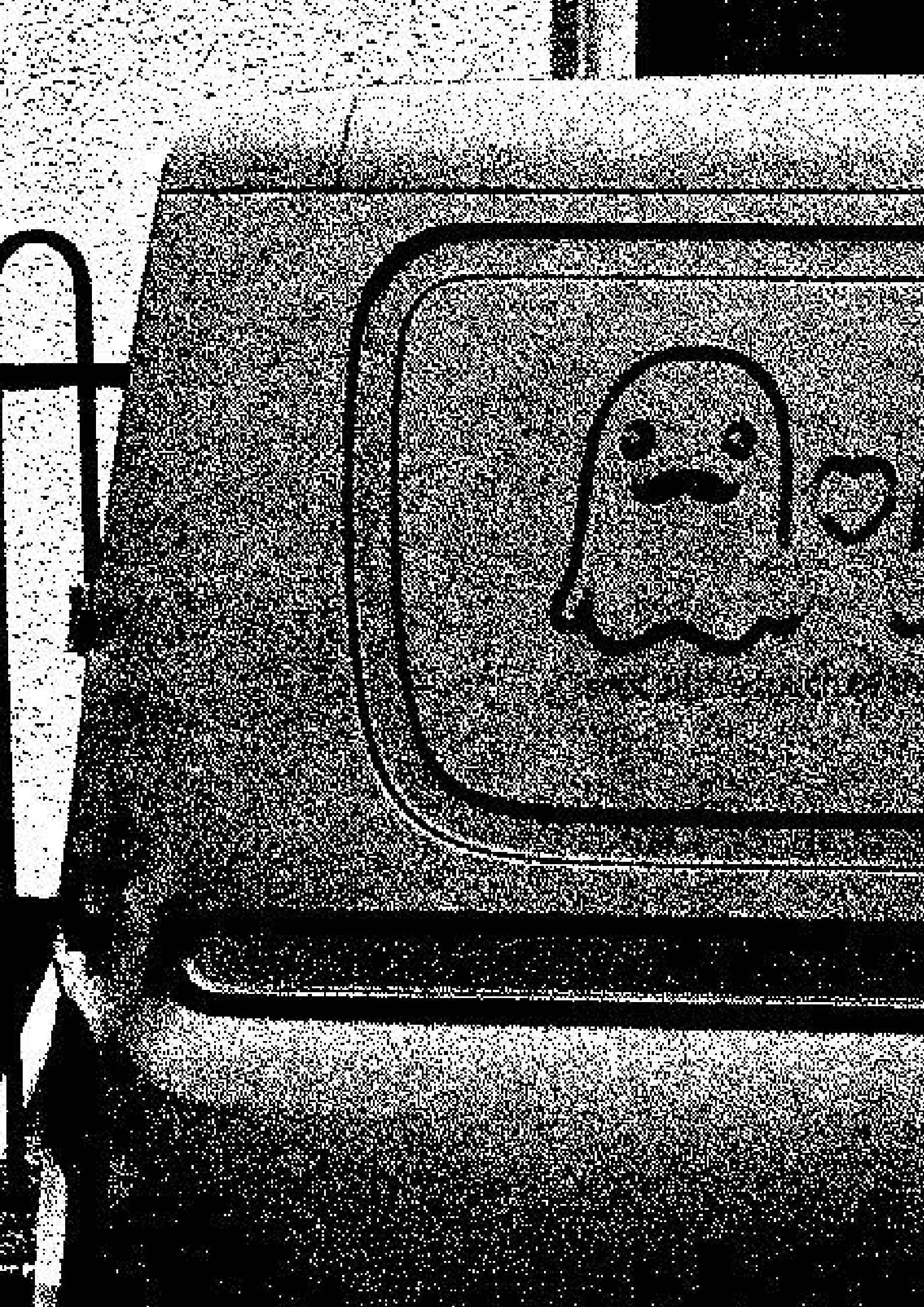
The work comes from visits, photographs and conversations, but it is also shaped by what caught my attention in each place. I'm comfortable with it being both documentary and a personal reading of what I found.

Leaving people out of the frame gives the viewer room to imagine daily life there. Who uses this space? What would it feel like to live here? Those questions matter to me more than making the image illustrate a recorded answer.

I return to the work of Adam Curtis, Jeremy Deller and Wolfgang Tillmans for the different ways they bring together observation, politics and personal vision. What I hope to make here is something that gives people time to look and listen, and perhaps to picture a different way of living.

Enrico Policardo

London, 2026





### A note

I made this project while living inside its own question - future-thinking and housing - which is proof enough that it isn't a speculative concern but a concrete one, urgent for me and my family as much as for a lot of people out there.

My hope is that you leave not with faith, and not with easy hope, but with the awareness that a different future isn't only possible - it's already been built.

My thanks go to everyone who has supported me through these years and kept my whole roaming existence going, and above all to my partner Rosamond, for the daily and unceasing support.

**voices and places**

# **Cressingham Gardens — Lambeth, London**

**A post-war estate that resisted  
Lambeth Council's 2015  
demolition plans with its own  
resident-authored People's Plan,  
showing refurbishment was  
deliverable for a fraction of the  
cost of knocking it down.**

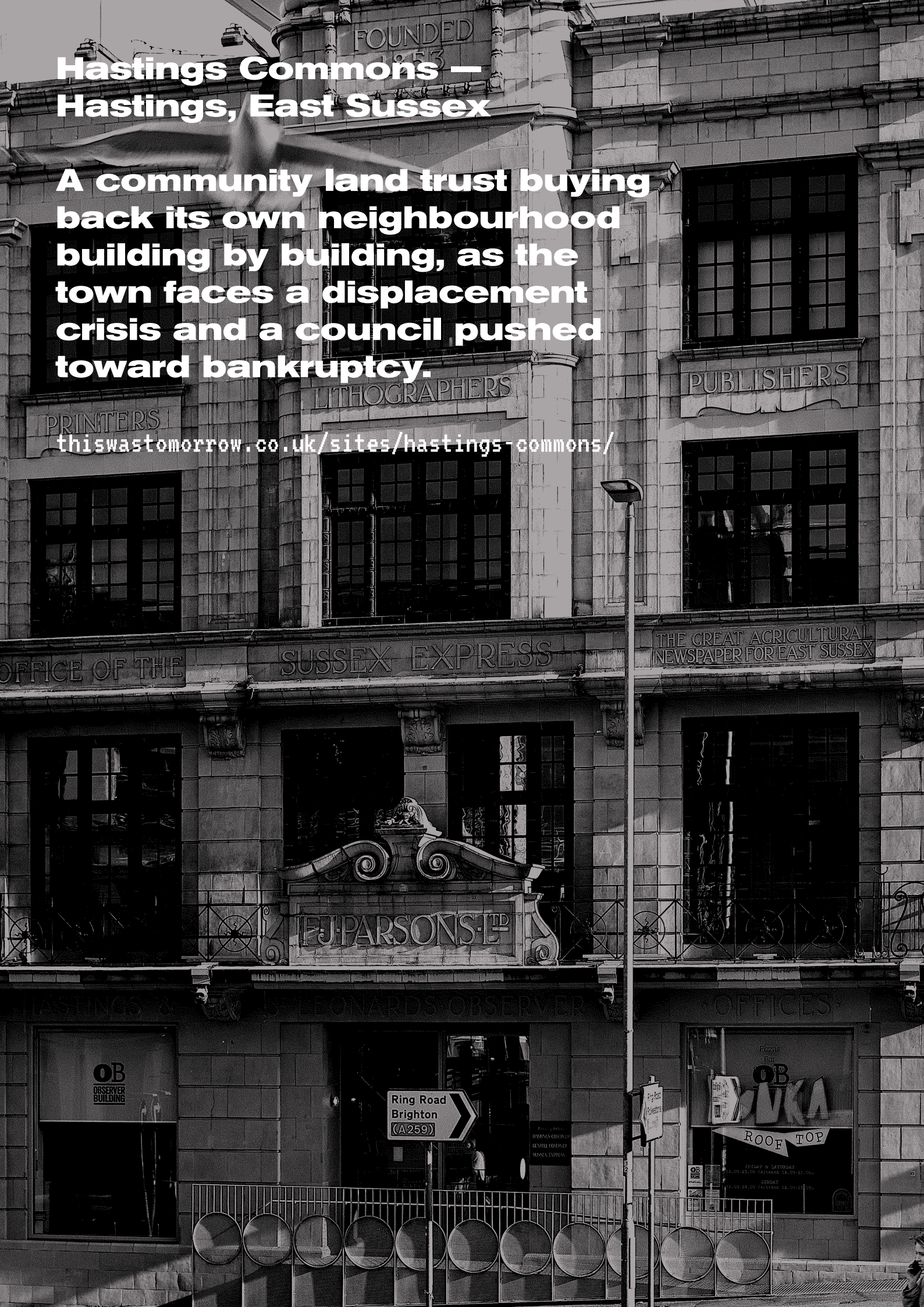
[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/cressingham-gardens](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/cressingham-gardens)

**ROPERS WALK**

# Hastings Commons — Hastings, East Sussex

**A community land trust buying  
back its own neighbourhood  
building by building, as the  
town faces a displacement  
crisis and a council pushed  
toward bankruptcy.**

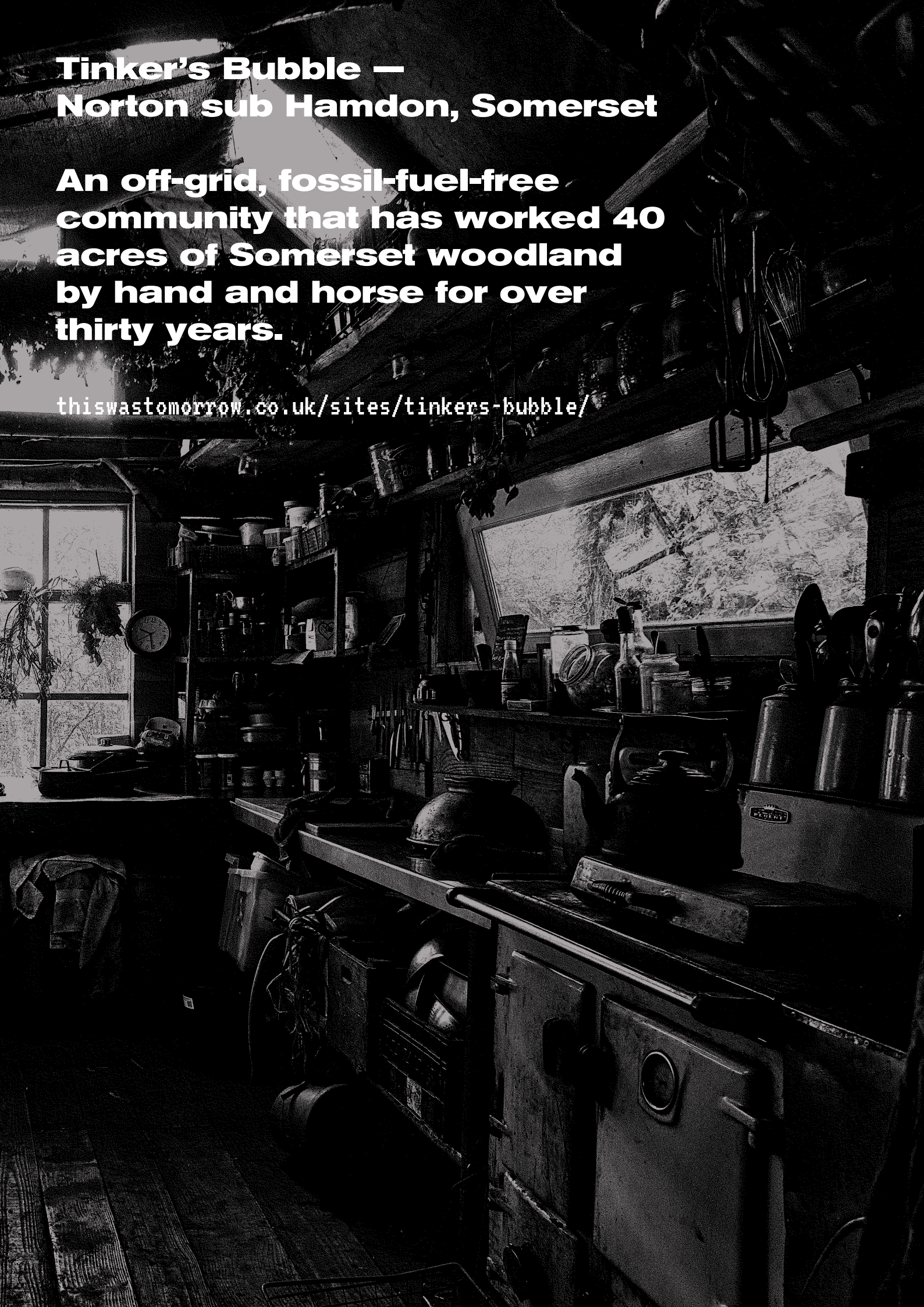
[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/hastings-commons/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/hastings-commons/)



# **Tinker's Bubble — Norton sub Hamdon, Somerset**

**An off-grid, fossil-fuel-free  
community that has worked 40  
acres of Somerset woodland  
by hand and horse for over  
thirty years.**

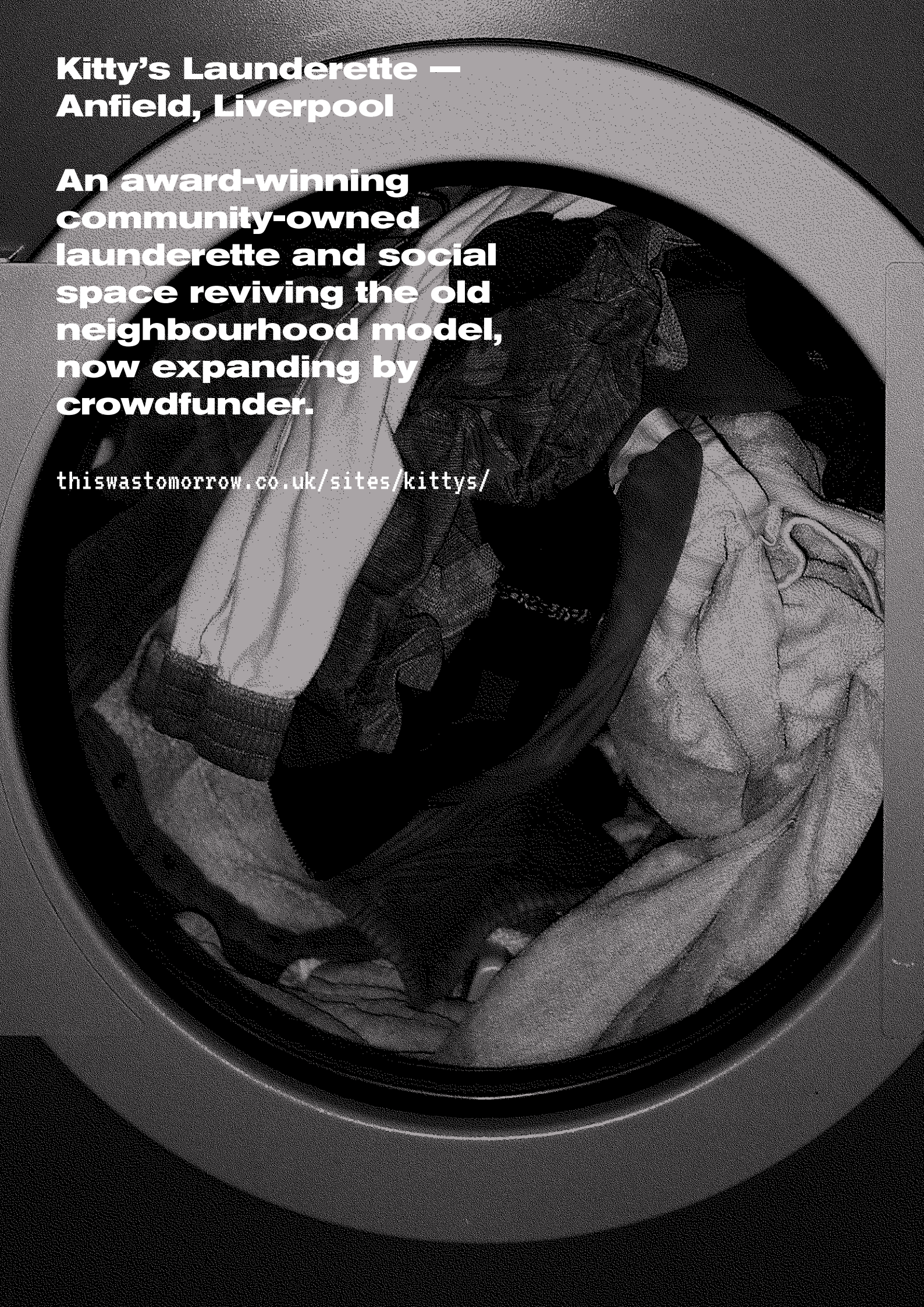
[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/tinkers-bubble/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/tinkers-bubble/)



## **Kitty's Launderette — Anfield, Liverpool**

**An award-winning  
community-owned  
launderette and social  
space reviving the old  
neighbourhood model,  
now expanding by  
crowdfunder.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kittys/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kittys/)



## **Two Up Two Down — Anfield, Liverpool**

**The new name for Homebaked  
Community Land Trust, a  
community-led organisation  
rooted in Anfield and Everton,  
rebuilding a terrace and a high  
street around a co-operatively  
run bakery. Begun with artist  
Jeanne van Heeswijk.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/two-up-two-down/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/two-up-two-down/)

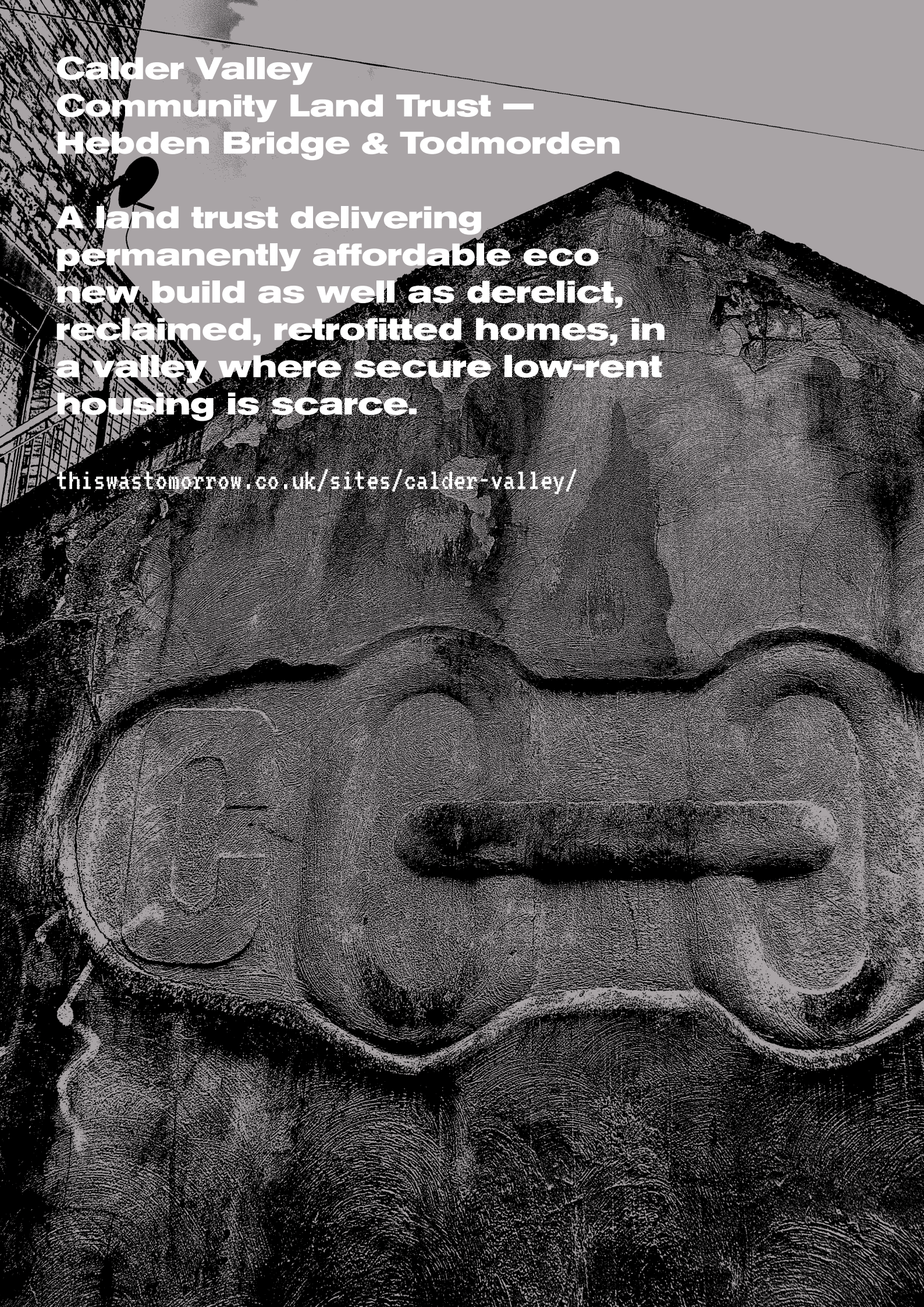
# **Granby Four Streets — Liverpool**

**The Toxteth community land trust - born from a residents' fight against demolition - who took derelict Victorian terraces into community ownership and won the 2015 Turner Prize with the Assemble collective.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/granby/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/granby/)

Builds





# **Calder Valley Community Land Trust — Hebden Bridge & Todmorden**

**A land trust delivering  
permanently affordable eco  
new build as well as derelict,  
reclaimed, retrofitted homes, in  
a valley where secure low-rent  
housing is scarce.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/calder-valley/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/calder-valley/)

# **OWCH / New Ground — High Barnet, London**

**The UK's first senior  
cohousing community, built  
by a group of older women  
on the site of a former  
convent and designed with  
them by architects Pollard  
Thomas Edwards.**

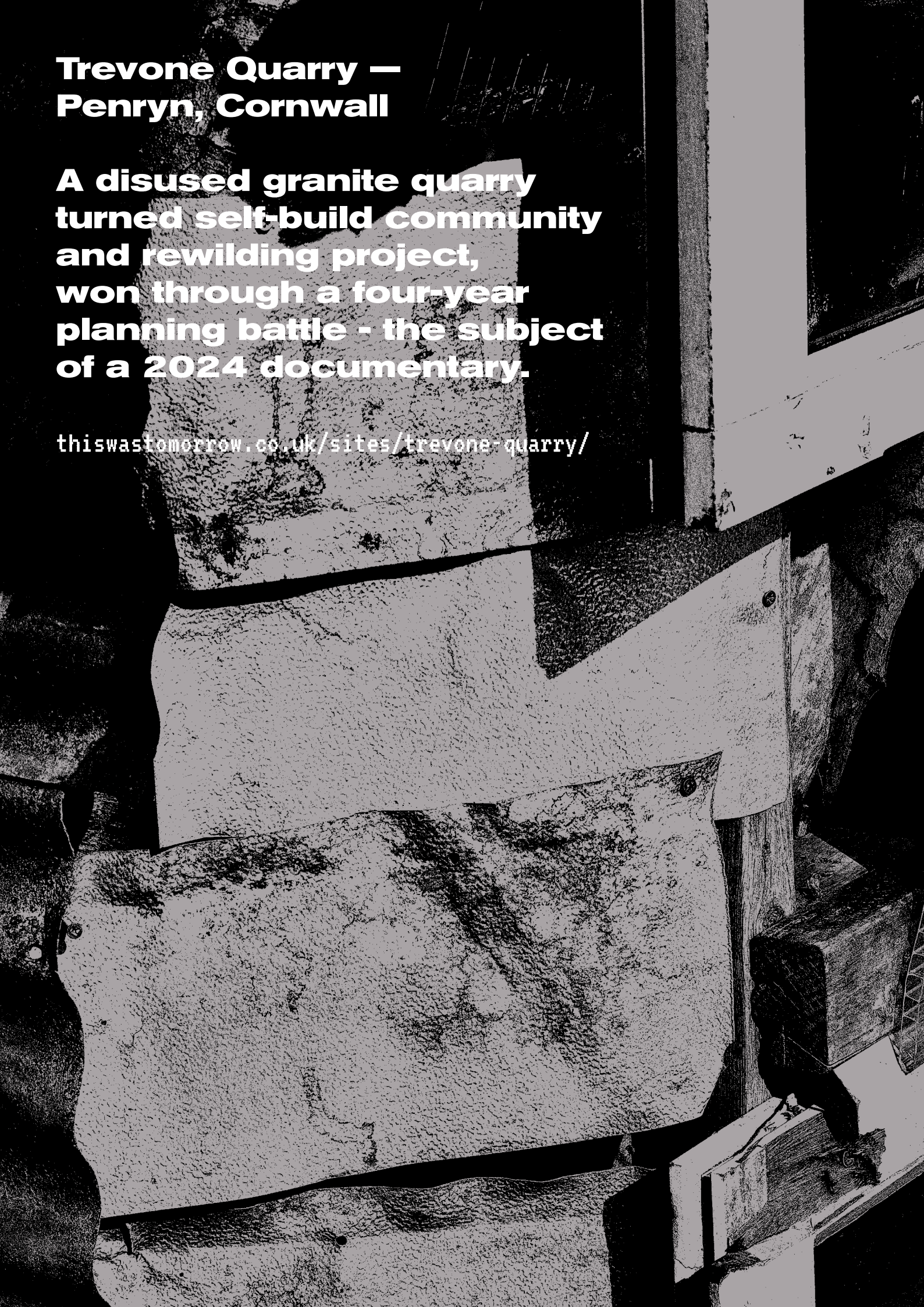
[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/owch-new-ground/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/owch-new-ground/)



# **Trevone Quarry — Penryn, Cornwall**

**A disused granite quarry  
turned self-build community  
and rewilding project,  
won through a four-year  
planning battle - the subject  
of a 2024 documentary.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/trevone-quarry/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/trevone-quarry/)



# **Kesoberi — Newlyn, Cornwall**

**A community farm and housing  
co-operative in the making  
near Newlyn, in a county where  
affordable rural housing has all  
but vanished.**

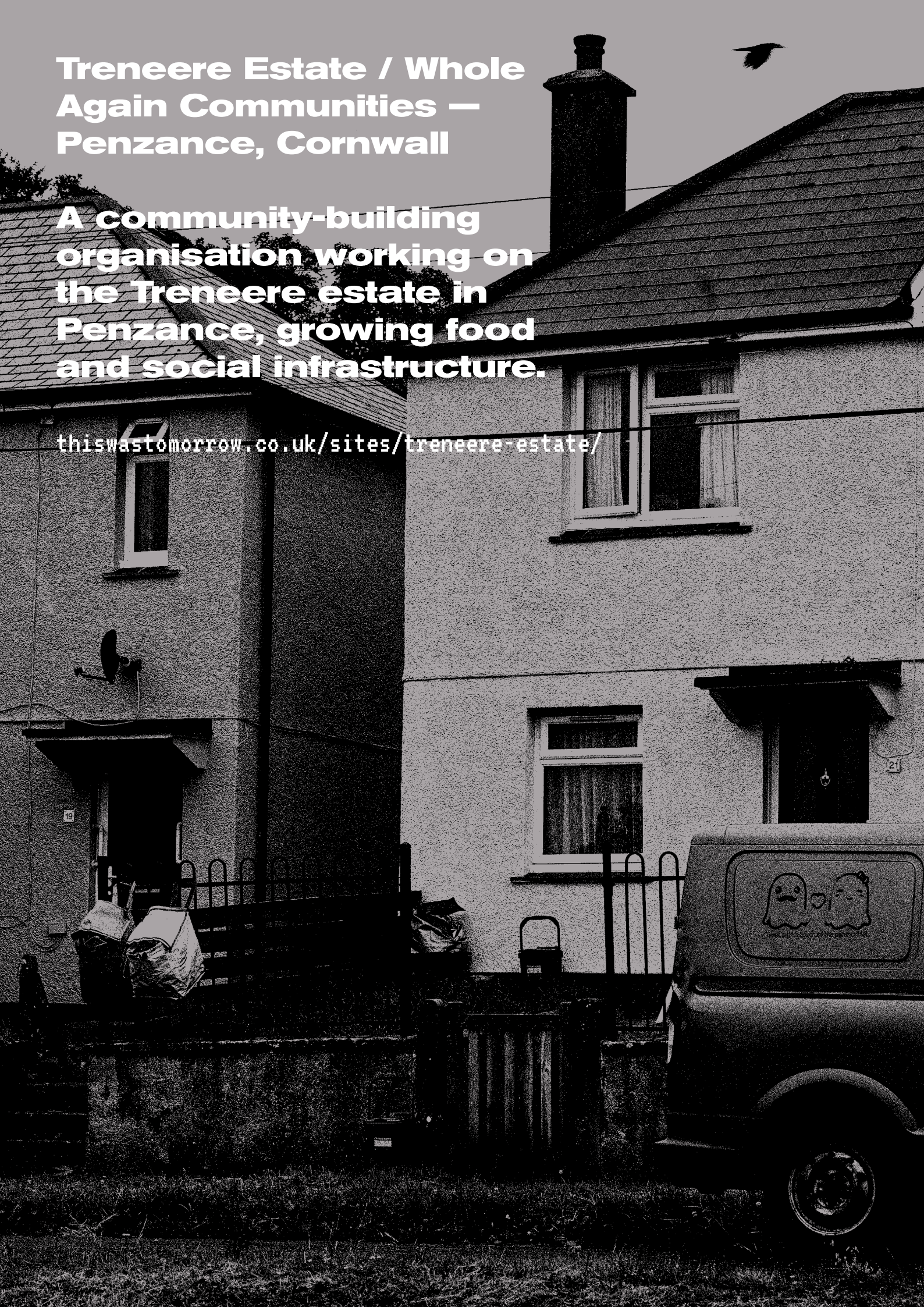
[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kesoberi-community-farm/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kesoberi-community-farm/)



# Treneere Estate / Whole Again Communities — Penzance, Cornwall

**A community-building organisation working on the Treneere estate in Penzance, growing food and social infrastructure.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/treneere-estate/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/treneere-estate/)



**LILAC —  
Leeds**

**Low Impact Living Affordable  
Community: a co-operative  
of straw-bale homes with an  
income-linked affordability  
model, co-founded by urban  
geographer Paul Chatterton.**

[thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/lilac/](http://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/lilac/)

UTOPIA